Rolling Stone
Sep 2012 Middle East

'Homeland' is Where the Art is

How Iranian actor Navid Negahban made a terrorist into one of TV's most watchable characters

By Matt Ross

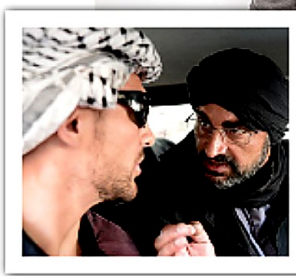
THE SECOND SEASON of *Homeland*, which begins airing at the end of September, is already being heralded as one of 2012's most anticipated TV events. The first season of the Golden Globe-winning drama

PROFILE

series revolved around a game of cat-and-mouse between former POW Nicholas Brody and CIA agent Carrie Mathison, but for many it was shadowy Al Qaeda agent Abu Nazir who emerged as one of TV's most fascinating antagonists. But were it not for Iranian actor Navid Negahban, Nazir might have been little more than a minor character in the hit show. "When I went for the first meeting, and I spoke with [writers Alex Gansa and Howard Gordon], this character was just one or two lines on the script," Negahban says from L.A. "Even my agent was asking me, 'Why do you even want to do this?' And I said, 'You don't see the potential.' I read the script and I saw the depth of this character. And when I had my meeting with Alex and Howard, we were all seeing the same thing. We were seeing a man who is struggling to make his point."

Plundering the hidden depths of characters is something that Negahban has been doing throughout a career that has taken him from Mashhad in Iran to the hallowed halls of Hollywood. And it's the roundabout journey that he's taken on his way to L.A. that has, he believes, made him into such a capable character actor. "My journey was my schooling," he says. "Every country that I went to, I tried to find a small hole in the wall [where I could study] different styles and techniques of how people were revealing their emotions. I think that's what gave me the ability to play all these diverse characters."

Born in Iran to a banker father and a schoolteacher mother, the 20-year-old Negahban left in 1985, at the height of the Iran-Iraq War. Years earlier, a part in a school play had convinced him that acting was what he wanted to do. "I was up there, and I could see how I was able to change the mood of the audience – how I was able to make them laugh," Negahban recalls. "It was like I was in control, and I kind of fell in love with it." Though an unorthodox vocation ("My parents wanted me to be a doctor"), Negahban had his heart set on an acting career. His first stop after leaving Iran was Turkey, but he eventually found his way to Germany, where he lived for eight-and-a-half years. Working for a theater company, Negahban won roles in such varied productions as *Sunday In The Park With George*, *Puss in Boots* and even *The Rocky Horror Show* – quite the departure for a man raised in a traditional Iranian family. "I took my dad to see the play, and I put him right in the front row," Negahban says of his run in *Rocky Horror*. "I gave him an umbrella, and I said to him, 'Dad, I need you to understand something. When you see the person next to you open his umbrella, I need *you* to open *your* umbrella.'"



METHOD MAN
Navid Negahban has become one of the most respected character actors in Hollywood. (Left) As Abu Nazir in *Homeland*.

Negahban recalls his years in Germany fondly, but says he felt a need to change things up again. He moved to San Diego, where he enrolled in a college theater program so he could learn the American style of acting. It didn't last long. After Negahban had helped a pair of fellow students to a rapturous reception in their finals, a professor (whose instructions the Iranian's advice had contradicted) took the actor to one side. "He said to me, 'I'd like you to leave my theater company and never come back. And if you ever become famous, I don't want to know about it.'" It was actually a blessing in disguise. That year, Negahban appeared in short film *Boundaries*, directed by Greg Durbin. The movie won the Grand Jury prize at the Slamdance Film Festival, and Negahban was nominated for Best Actor at Method Fest in California. "That opened doors for me, and brought me to L.A. That's how my career got started."

Many of his early jobs were Arab roles, but rather than railing against such typecasting, Negahban instead saw it as an opportunity to delve deeply into characters that might otherwise have been left as hollow stereotypes. "I was getting frustrated, but at the same time I was enjoying them," Negahban says. "I have friends who are not playing, for example, so-called 'terrorist characters.' For me, what's important is to tell the truth. To portray this character as truthfully as possible. So I work on those projects where I can talk with the director and the writers about the characters. This character is not *just* a villain. This character is a father. He's a husband. He might have been a teacher. I always try to find a hero inside my character. If you look at my work, even when I'm playing a villain I hope I'm able to portray layers so that you see their journey."

The enigmatic Abu Nazir is set to become a series regular in season two of *Homeland*, giving Negahban an even greater chance to explore what motivates his character's vendetta against the U.S. "Let's just say that you will see the extent of the web," Negahban says. "How connected he is. You will go deeper into the relationships with these characters. You will just see more of his influence." Much like his onscreen counterpart, however, the actor is cautiously secretive. "I need to be careful... I think that if I reveal anything it's going to be the end of my career."

FROM TOP: BOBBY QUILLARD; WWW.QUILLARDINC.COM; SUPPLIED

THE Hollywood REPORTER

About Town

AMBLING REPORTER *By Merle Ginsberg & Gary Baum*

Ratner

Ratner Finds Religion

Seems like **Brett Ratner**'s inner good boy is coming to the fore. The former Yeshiva student was recently spotted pre-Hanukkah in the halls of UTA's new Beverly Hills building with an orthodox rabbi, slapping mezuzahs on the doors of agents **Jeremy Zimmer** and **Blair Kohan**. What's more, he's not even a UTA client: The CAA-repped Ratner was there on a casting meeting. Calls to Ratner's rep were not returned.

Gore Goading Hollywood

Call him the stealth laureate. **Al Gore** slipped into town Dec. 6 for a quick chat with Hollywood environmentalists at the Beverly Hills estate of mega-concert producer **Kevin Wall**, the force behind Live Earth, a partnership with Gore. Sources tell *THR* about 75 guests including **Lawrence Bender**, **Leonard Nimoy** and **Lynn Lear** gathered to hear Gore's impassioned plea for the entertainment industry to renew its focus on climate change. While in town, Gore also lunched with *An Inconvenient Truth* director **Davis Guggenheim**. At a dinner for the Children's Defense Fund, the documentarian bemoaned global warming slipping off the public agenda. "Do you think it still matters to people?" he wondered.

Ebersol: This Is 30

It's his party and he'll go all out if he wants to. Hochberg Ebersol Co. co-founder **Charlie Ebersol** (a 2012 inductee to *THR*'s Reality TV 50 Most Powerful List) celebrated his 30th birthday with an over-the-top fete Dec. 8 for which he enlisted the advice of Disney Imagineers to turn nearly every inch of his two-acre Holmby Hills property into "Charlieland," replete with an old-time tram and a Jungle Cruise-like ride. Guests including **Ryan Phillippe**, **Kellan Lutz** and **Mekhi Phifer** bought tickets for each activity, such as paying $300 for a zip-line ride, and raised $60,000 for Charity: Water. The night was capped by a performance of "We Are the Champions" by a Queen cover band. The ruckus brought Ebersol a Facebook poke from neighbor **Crystal Harris**, **Hugh Hefner**'s fiancee, the following day (the Playboy Mansion is just a short stroll away). Laughs Ebersol: "She said, 'Your party sounded amazing.' Apparently she's a pretty big Queen fan. I told her I'd bring over some bundt cake to apologize for the noise."

Haim Talks Hillary in 2016

Barack Obama has yet to officially begin his second term, but that hasn't stopped **Hillary Clinton**'s admirers from all but anointing her as the Democrats' next presidential candidate. If anybody would know what she thinks of all this, it's **Haim Saban** — a longtime intimate of both Clintons. When asked by *THR* about the speculation at the recent March of Dimes luncheon at the Beverly Hills Hotel, Saban grinned broadly and said, "Ask me about Hillary in March" — presumably after she has stepped down as Obama's secretary of state.

Clinton: Saban's superwoman.

From left: Negahban, Schwartz and Pamela Adlon at Showtime's holiday soirée.

Abu Nazir's 180 Turn

It was strange enough to spot **Navid Negahban**, Abu Nazir on *Homeland*, at the Showtime holiday party Dec. 3 in Beverly Hills in a Christmas sweater — let alone to hear what the actor wants to do next. (Spoiler alert: His terrorist character was killed by the CIA in the Dec. 9 episode.) "I want to do comedy," the Iranian-born actor pronounced to *THR*. Negahban said he's been pushing Showtime president **David Nevins** to let him guest on *Shameless*, and he spent time posing at the party with **Ben Schwartz** of *House of Lies*, a show he wouldn't mind working on, either. Even though the intense actor's résumé is jammed with such dark dramas as *24*, *Fringe*, *NCIS: Los Angeles*, *The Shield* and *Law & Order*, he reminded us he was in a Slamdance-winning short called *Boundaries* in 2001 in which he did a comic turn as a mute trombonist. But the strangest thing the actor said on this night was, "I don't even have cable — let alone Showtime!" THR